Banned Books

WHY BOOKS ARE BANNED, AND WHY YOU SHOULD READ THEM ANYWAY!

— CNU LIBRARY

How can we read 'harmful' information?

Books are available for free on:

- Libby (eBook & audiobook app)
- Project Gutenberg (older, out of copyright books)
- Some audiobooks are included in Spotify memberships

Tips on informed reading:

- Look up reviews of a book to see what others say and have experienced.
- Search online: who wrote the book, why it was written, when it was published, how it was received when published.
- Discuss the book with a friend, librarian, or person who has read it.

READ MORE:

TERMS:

Banned book:
A book that has been removed from a public or school library, or has been restricted in some way.

Challenged book:
A book that has been suggested for removal from a public or school library, but is either still in progress, or was denied (and still remains in the library).

Intellectual freedom:
The right of every individual to both seek and receive information from all points of view, without restriction.

Censorship:
The practice of suppressing or deleting anything considered objectionable.

Critical thinking:
The objective analysis and evaluation of an issue in order to form a judgment.

NOTE: This zine is about book banning in the US, but books are banned all over the world. ALSO: For a list of citations and more info, scan the QR code on the last page of this zine.

Why do books get banned?

An upset parent, group, or organization finds a book harmful to read (for youth under 18 years old).

How does this happen?

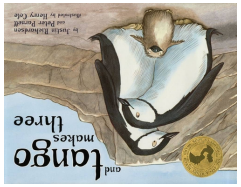
Someone submits a formal **challenge** in writing to their library to be considered by librarians (this takes time).

What's the end result?

Challenged books may be:

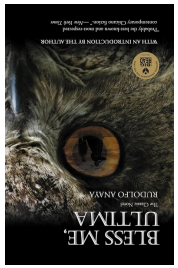
- Removed from a library.
- Moved to a different section.
- Restricted to certain ages.
- Removed from required reading lists in courses.
- Overruled, and kept in the library.

EXAMPLES:



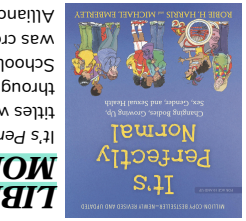
PENGUINS THREATEN FAMILY STRUCTURE

First banned in Florida in 2008, then later removed from elementary school libraries all around the US. This book was banned for depicting a same-sex relationship between penguins, which has been called "unsuited to children," "anti-family" and "anti-ethnic." *And Tango Makes Three* is the true story of two male penguins who, with the help of a zookeeper, create a nontraditional family and raise a baby penguin at the Central Park Zoo.



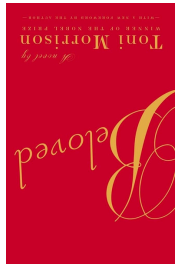
BURNED IN NEW MEXICO

Bless Me, Ultima was famously burned in 1981 by the Bloomfield School Board in San Juan County, New Mexico. It has been challenged many times since then, most recently in 2022 for advocating occult beliefs, containing offensive language, depicting violence, and being sexually explicit. New Mexico State Senator Christina Donisthorpe stated in a 1982 interview, "We took the books out and personally saw that they were burned." *Bless Me, Ultima* is about a young boy, Antonio, who befriends an old curandera, a Mexican healer, and feels her guidance throughout his life.



LIBRARIES VS. MOMS OF LIBERTY

It's Perfectly Normal was one of 58 titles withdrawn from libraries throughout the Walton County School District (FL). The list of titles was created by the Florida Citizens Alliance with the help of a teacher who is a Moms for Liberty member. *It's Perfectly Normal* was withdrawn due to its illustrations of sex and naked bodies. *It's Perfectly Normal* provides sex, puberty, and body education for tweens & teens. Harris knew this book would be controversial but was determined to write it anyway.



HIGH SCHOOL TEEN GETS NIGHTMARES

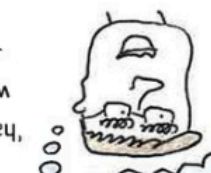
Beloved is one of the most frequently banned books in the US. In 2021, a parent in Fairfax County school district, Virginia called for *Beloved* to be removed from AP English curriculum for giving him nightmares. The school board voted to keep Beloved, but allowed students to opt out of it if uncomfortable with its content. *Beloved* is about Sethe, a young woman who escapes slavery but is plagued by the memory of her deceased baby. Morrison wrote this book to give a voice to forgotten people in history.

Is information harmful?

In a study by Christopher Ferguson:
There was a positive correlation between banned book reading and civic engagement levels! Students who read more banned books were also more likely to vote and volunteer.

Consequences of book banning:

- Restricted access to information for minors
- Contributes to an overall trend (restricted speech in news, social media platforms)
- On a national level: decreased reading levels and development of critical thinking skills.



WHAT AN INTERESTING DISCUSSION ON THE MANY THEMES AND INTERPRETATIONS OF THIS BOOK!

Our take:
You can fight back against potentially 'harmful' information with critical thinking skills!
— CNU Library